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My Reflections On Prof. Dwyer's Lecture "Violent Death: Homicide in Global Perspective"

This Wednesday, Professor Philip Dwyer at the University of Newcastle, an Australian historian that studies the violence in human history, held a lecture that focused on homicide in global perspective.

In the beginning of the lecture, Prof. Dwyer explained why he chose homicide as a starting point to introduce his research on violence. This was because violence contains extensive meanings and are hard to be analyzed quantitatively, however, the statistics of homicide are measurable, therefore, homicide is a form of violence that can be relatively easier to study quantitatively.

Then he introduced some characteristics of homicide. First, he pointed out that every homicide has a ripple effect, for example, grieves of both assailant's and victim's relatives are ripple effect of homicide that is difficult to relieve in a short period. Second, Prof. Dwyer said that behind every homicide, there are some personal reasons, and these reasons may differ significantly case by case. As a vivid example, Prof. Dwyer told a true story of a boy in Newcastle, that he killed his neighbor because of some really trivial reasons such as noise. At last, Prof. Dwyer introduced a novel theory, that biological and evolutionary reasons that can be decisive factors that are able to explain why homicide happens — this theory treats violence as a part of our evolutionary history.

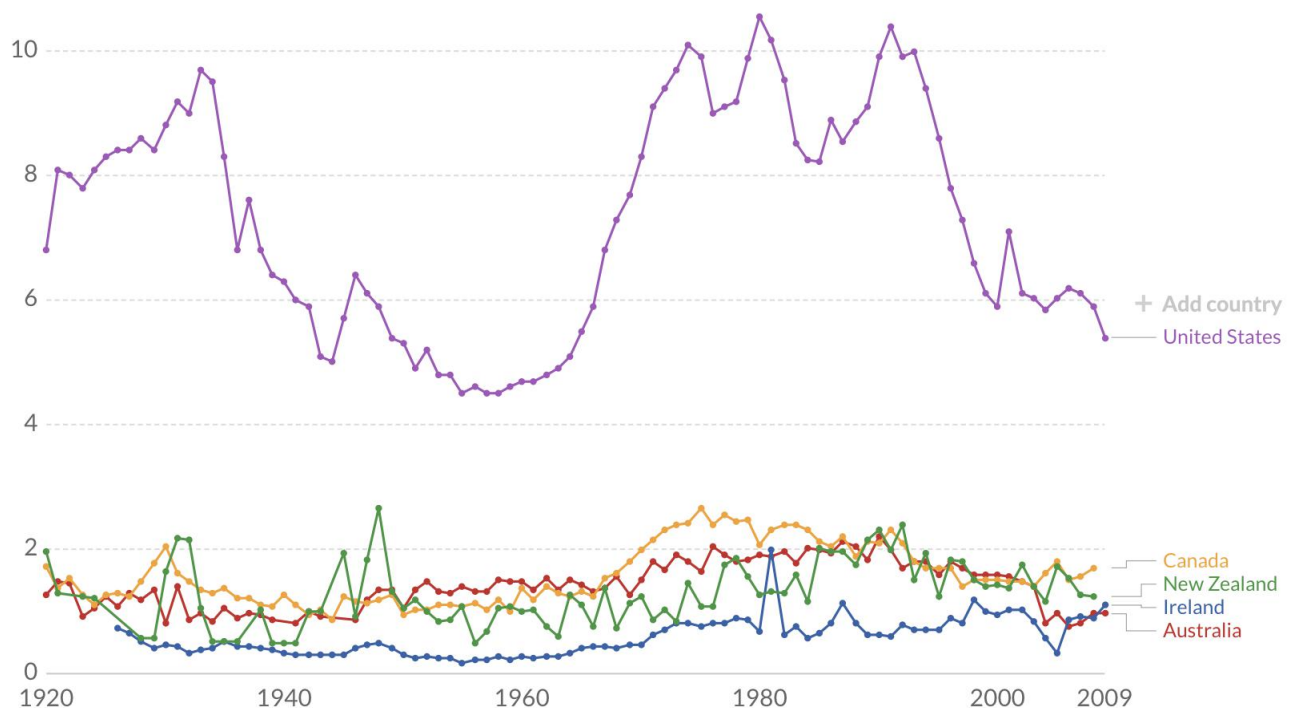
Next Prof. Dwyer analyzed some of the causes of homicide. In this part, he especially focused on two mainstream ideas, that the first states that homicide is the result of individual's inability to control his spontaneous emotions, and the second argues that homicide is the result of masculine honor or reaction to insult. Also, he showed some interesting statistics of the American homicide rate.

Compared to European countries such as Germany, France, and Italy, East Asian countries such as China, Japan, and Korea, the homicide rate of the United States is extremely high. He pointed out that the homicide rate in the United States is strongly relative to the political and economic situations. I analyzed the graph below, and I found that the first peak of homicide rate happened in 1933, just the year when the New Deal was launched by President Franklin D. Roosevelt. After WWII, as the American economy prospered, the homicide rate dropped steadily. However, during the period of the Vietnam War and the Civil Rights Movement, the homicide rate ascended rapidly, and reached its peak in the 1970s and 1990s when stagflation deeply beset American economy. But as President Bill Clinton took power and conducted his reform, the homicide rate became lower and lower until today.

Homicide rate

Homicides per 100,000 people year.

Our World
in Data



Source: Clio Infra

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Figure 1. Homicide Rate Statistics that Prof. Dwyer Cited¹

¹ Max Roser. Homicide Rate. Our World in Data. 2017. Retrieved from <<https://ourworldindata.org/homicides>>.